

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Lent 3

The Only Thing More Powerful Than Hate is Love

Journeying

8 March 2026



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540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on BEACH SPRING and LLANGLOFFAN

Adoration (Florence B. Price)

Aria (Elizabeth Turner)

Andante espressivo (Hedwige Chrétien)

Andante (Fanny Mendelssohn Hensel)

Prelude and Fugue in A minor, BWV 543 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin & Lauren Seely

Nothing brings home how finite we are
like leaving behind the protection of civilization
and making a journey into wild places.
The longer we spread out beyond the street lights,
the more our fragile vulnerability becomes apparent.

Because in wilderness we are in contact with our vulnerability -
we are aware of our dependency,
we are exposed to unmanaged risk,
we are confronted with our physicality.

Yet, if we are open to the lessons of wilderness,
we can find, even as we stand against its harshest elements,
surprising places of active stillness that allow us
to rest, to dream, to resist, and to imagine,
a new world.

And even though wilderness often attempts to tell us we are
small and insignificant, the angels that surround us always and everywhere,
remind us we are interconnected through all time and space,
with the Holy One who knows the eternal beauty
of what is small and what is fragile.

On this third Sunday of Lent, we say together...
Accompany us, O God, in this perplexing season.
Breathe through us, Tender Presence,
and lead us through the journey of remembering
who, and whose, we are.

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Lenten Hymn of Gathering** *Bless Now, O God, the Journey*
Bless now, O God, the journey that all your people make,
The path through noise and silence, the way of give and take.
The trail is found in desert and winds the mountain round,
Then leads beside still waters, the road where faith is found

LLANGLOFFAN

Bless sojourners and pilgrims who share this winding way;
Your hope burns through the terrors, your love sustains the day.
We yearn for holy freedom while often we are bound;
Together we are seeking the road where faith is found.

Divine eternal lover, you meet us on the road.
We wait for lands of promise where milk and honey flow,
But waiting not for places, you meet us all around.
Our covenant is written on roads, as faith is found.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

Holy One,
as we continue on this, our Lenten Journey,
help us in these days to embrace change.
To change ourselves and our world -
to know the need for it,
to deal with the pain of it,
to feel the joy of it,
and to undertake this journey,
without needing to know
the destination.

*Help us in these days, O God,
to lean in and listen for your loving guidance,
as we journey through this sacred season.
From the depths of our common hope, we pray.
Amen and Amen.*

***Introit**

“Festive Peal”
Cathedral Ringers, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Director*

KAREN THOMPSON

***The Lord's Prayer for Lent**

Lauren Seely

*Loving Presence, luminous in all creation,
hallowed be your name.
Thy kin-dom come.
May we reflect on earth
the yielding perfection of the heavens.*

*Help us to receive an illumed measure from the earth this day.
Forgive us when we trespass against others,
human and other than human,
as we forgive others who trespass against us.*

*Keep us on the path of wisdom
when we are tempted to take the selfish path.
May it be your rule we follow,
your power we exercise,
and your radiance that allures.*

*May this be the truth that guides our lives,
the ground from which our future will grow,
until we meet again.* [BSanguin/dddc]
Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

*There is more than one kind of wilderness.
There is the wilderness of the soul, an often lonely, aching place.
There is the wilderness of the world, a place where words of love are everywhere,
yet people hunger for love because the imitations of love that perfuse our society
leave us empty, aching, hungry.*

-Dr. Wilda C. Gafney

In this place, we are students of love,
continually learning and discerning love's true expression.
We undertake this endeavor each time we gather
so that we might continue to be at peace within ourselves,
with each other, and with our world.

And so, we share an ancient greeting that speaks of this hopeful commitment.

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition
from the Gospel of Luke

Lauren Seely

Jesus returned from the Jordan filled with the Holy Spirit, and she led him into the desert for forty days, where he was tempted by the Devil. Jesus ate nothing during that time, at the end of which he was famished.

The Devil said to Jesus, "If you are God's Own, command this stone to turn into bread." Jesus answered, "Scripture has it, 'We don't live on bread alone.' "

Then the Devil took Jesus up higher and showed him all the nations of the world in a single instant. The Devil said, "I'll give you all the power and the glory of these nations; the power has been given to me and I can give it to whomever I wish. Prostrate yourself in homage before me, and it will all be yours." In reply, Jesus said, "Scripture has it: 'You will worship the Most High God; God alone will you adore.' "

Then the Devil led Jesus to Jerusalem, set him up on the parapet of the Temple and said, "If you are God's Own, throw yourself down from here, for scripture has it, 'God will tell the angels to take care of you; with their hands they'll support you, that you may never stumble on a stone.' " Jesus said to the Devil in reply, "It also says, 'Do not put God to the test.' " When the Devil had finished all this tempting, Jesus was left alone, as angels came to minister to him.

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

To all that is chaotic in you, let there come silence. Let there be a calming of the clamoring, a stilling of the voices that have laid their claim on you, that have made their home in you, that go with you even to the holy places but will not let you rest, will not let you hear your life with wholeness or feel the grace that fashioned you. Let what distracts you cease. Let what divides you cease. Let there come an end to what diminishes and demeans, and let depart all that keeps you in its cage. Let there be an opening into the quiet that lies beneath the chaos, where you find the dreams you did not think possible and see what shimmers within the storm.

-Jan Richardson

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of the Journey, you who calls us to travel with faith, hope, and love,
you who reminds us we are dust yet breathes into us the breath of life,
awaken us once again to the life you invite us to share -
with you, and with each other.

As we continue this Lenten Journey, help us on this day, O God,
to honestly acknowledge the vulnerability of our lives.
The reality is, we constantly find ourselves in unexpected,
wobbly moments of doubt, again and again.
We are still surprised when useless fear invades ferociously,
and the extended heart-pilgrimages for which we long
cause us to be filled with searching and sobering discontent.

We find ourselves slipping into those patterns of old behavior,
behavior that refuses efforts to be shaken off.
We find ourselves, once again, in troubling, hurtful relationships
and ongoing disillusionments of life,
that remind us life is not for the fainthearted.

Yet you always find ways to help us remember that you are always and forever with us,
Great Companion, and you assure us, again and again, we are never alone.

Because we do not travel alone,
you have brought us to this place, on this day,
and in this Sanctuary, in this sacred place we call home,
where we find a haven of welcome, and a circle of care,
that invites us to bring all that we are - and all that we are not -
into the fierce grace of your love and hope.

Lead us in the days to come on this Lenten Journey, Holy One,
to the angels of our time, who minister to us as they surround us with your love,
helping us to remember that together, we will grow strong
as we receive and share all these gifts that surround us,
in this, our time and place.

This morning, may it be so.
May it be so for all of us, O God.
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"i carry your heart"

JOHN DUKE

Laurel Irene, *Soloist*, Christoph Bull, *Piano*

Sermon

Journeying

Rev. Michael Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

We have lovingly been called to be a people of God.
Having been given this bread and cup as a reminder of God's love,
we now listen for God's presence in silence and in sound –
we listen in the voices of all people,
we listen to the music of creation,
and in this way, we are reconnected to God
through this holy meal.
In this time may we hear the voice
that calls us home to our Creator, Christ, and Spirit.

We remember the stories of Jesus,
the one who did not have a house of their own,
and yet found home whenever they came to the table with their friends.
To help them remember God's great love for them,
Jesus would take the bread, hold it up for all to see,
and say, 'When you eat this, remember the love with which it is given.'

And then, Jesus would take a cup of the fruit of the vine,
pouring it out for all of them to see and saying,
'This cup is poured out for you – remember the love
that you are now called to give.'

Prayer of Blessing

God of fresh bread and newly harvested fruit of the vine,
we sense your presentness among us
in grace-filled moments of sharing,
in carefully created communities of loving solidarity,
in holy times of birthing new life
from the renewing of our minds.

*We delight in the moving of your steadfast Spirit
that calls us to find water for the thirsty,
invites us to prepare meals
for all who hunger, and
give us the gifts to welcome all in our midst.*

May it ever be so.
Amen and Amen.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Lauren Seely

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Peace Is Every Step"
Cathedral Choir

DAVID MONTOYA

***Lenten Doxology**

Praise God from whom all blessings flow.
Praise God, all creatures here below.
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts.
Creator, Christ, and Holy Ghost.

***Offering Prayer**

Lauren Seely

Lead us, Holy One, in this Lenten Journey
to the angels of our time,
to the blessedness of this earth, to your life-giving waters,
and surround us with the winds of your spirit,
that we may grow strong
and that we may share
all these gifts that surround us
with our siblings, both near and far..

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

As we continue in the wilderness of our Lenten journey,
may we find among the lines God has inscribed
onto our hearts and souls and minds,
beautiful words made from dust-
what will sustain and challenge,
comfort and call us.

*May they be bread for the journey;
may they be manna for our way.
Amen and Amen.*

Choral Response

"Come Out The Wilderness"
Cathedral Choir, Molly Pease, *Soloist*

NEGRO SPIRITUAL

***Hymn for the Journey**

Journey of Faith

BEACH SPRING

To a journey God has called us,
To a life of love and hope;
In the light and in the shadow,
God is with us as we go.
Faith that grows with each new challenge,
Trust that leads through paths unknown,
We, as pilgrims, walk together
In the journey to our home.

For the strength of faithful witness
Lived through days of joy and tears;
And the gift of grace sufficient
For the ever-flowing years;
For the richness of Your mercy
To Thee, Lord, we give our praise.
May our lives reflect Your glory
'Till the close of all our days.

Go we now to be God's people,
Go we now our faith to live.
Help us learn from one another
Faith to keep, a faith to give.
Go we now on life's great journey,
Go we now, but not alone.
With God's people, by God's Spirit,
Faith leads forward, faith leads on.

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence
Fugue in A minor, BWV 543/2 - Reprise (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Inside The Music

"Two songs about journeying through the wilderness of life this week also focus on centering. 20th Century American John Duke is considered one of America's most important writers of art song. Art song is the classical term for songs written as songs, or, not written to be part of a larger work. Their classical origins surface in the 19th century more or less as popular music for people to play in parlors, bars, and gatherings, and eventually, concert halls. The rise of popular music in America and Europe complicated their position in society, and art song became a designation for songs that would only be heard in solo recitals in concert halls. A significant and unfortunate culture clash bleached them of their wide communicating power. Duke, however, demonstrates just how effective songs in this idiom can be at deeply connecting people to themselves. Set to a text by e.e. cummings, Duke, like the poet, demonstrates how simplicity in the hands of a master can have incredible impact. The poem is powered by the image of a journey. He speaks of carrying the heart of another anywhere, and that whatever is done, their love remains centered. The ubiquity here impresses. We all travel about, and we all do lots of whatevers in our own perceived wilderness. Then cummings begins his famous redacting and refining. "I fear no fate," "I want no world," and eventually condensing the human experience into breathtaking focus "whatever a moon has always meant, and whatever a sun will always sing is you." Note the use of the article "a" instead of "the" for moon and sun as another reference to ongoing change. Each moon and sun we encounter is another one on the journey. He continues with a signature build in energy beginning with "here is the secret nobody knows. . ." and continues with a string of impossibly enticing metaphors before landing on the simple secret that "I carry you in my heart." He is famous for his punch lines. Duke responds by granting cummings' words a sonic breadth to live through. He establishes and frequently returns to E major throughout the piece. It is the sonic alignment of the central text "I carry you in my heart." His accompaniment rolls easy as the soloist smoothly charts different, but generally simple, courses inspired by subtle harmonic shifts. Throughout the piece he finds moments to migrate into parallel key areas. Composers in the 20th century enjoyed splitting the octave into equal parts. If you read my notes on Duke Ellington a few weeks ago, you'll remember he chose a split of four equal segments. John Duke, here, chooses a split of three equal segments, or major 3rd relationships. In an early part of the piece he shifts from E to Ab, and at a similar distance from the end, he chooses C. The resulting journey through non-tonal key areas feels like chapters in a long story presented at speed. Just like with Ellington, the use of these harmonic relationships gives Duke smooth migration patterns into otherwise distant-sounding areas. In short, we're taken on a trip, yet, like cummings, he wraps that complexity in the simpleness of broken chord accompaniment and a steady roll. Though life may seem too vast to understand, they both guide us to consider that the core of our experience remains with us in the form of the love we carry. David Montoya is a SoCal native and a friend. I've loved his setting of Thich Naht Hanh's "Peace Is Every Step" ever since we premiered it years ago. Like Duke, Montoya leans on the simplicity of rolling chords and drifting melodic passages to express the monk's core sentiment. The drum, however, holds the magic of the piece. Every step is heard in the steady drum that outlines the somewhat unusual 7/4 meter. I played the drum while conducting the last time we did it out of necessity. In doing so, though, I discovered a deeper layer to the music. Conducting and drumming in 7/4 requires a certain meditative state. His 7/4 choice he once said to me was to mirror the uneven paths we walk. As a counter to that wilderness image, Thich Naht Hanh encourages us into places of awareness. The sun, the flowers, the green, the wind, each speak to us when we have embraced peacefulness in our steps. So often people look to nature to calm them. He encourages us into calm awareness so that nature can speak to us. Then nature can feed our peacefulness as a symbiotic partner. Just like with cummings' reference to love being a centering agent in life, so too, when awareness and peaceful focus center each step we take, the world opens to our journey with loving arms. Then the wilderness of our choosing or the wilderness forced upon us share the common relationship of us recognizing who we are in the midst of whatever may come our way."

~ Dr. David Harris

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